

What Is Active Listening?

Tips for practicing this essential communication skill by Amy Gallo

Are you a good listener at work? You might think you are because you put away distractions, stay quiet, and nod your head when someone is talking to you. You might even repeat back your conversation partner's main points to demonstrate that you've heard and absorbed them. These are all smart things to do, but they can still leave the speaker feeling unheard or even dismissed.

Active listening involves mastering a whole host of other skills — from learning how to read subtle cues to controlling your own emotional response. It requires both empathy and self-awareness.

In this article, I'm going to explain what active listening looks and feels like, and how to improve this essential communication skill.

What Is Active Listening?

Active listening is when you not only hear what someone is saying, but also attune to their thoughts and feelings. It turns a conversation into an active, non-competitive, two-way interaction.

Robin Abrahams and Boris Groysberg from Harvard Business School describe active listening as having three aspects: cognitive, emotional, and behavioral. Here's how they define each aspect in their article, "How to Become a Better Listener":

- **Cognitive:** Paying attention to all the information, both explicit and implicit, that you are receiving from the other person, comprehending, and integrating that information
- **Emotional:** Staying calm and compassionate during the conversation, including managing any emotional reactions (annoyance, boredom) you might experience.
- **Behavioral:** Conveying interest and comprehension verbally and nonverbally

They go on to write, "Getting good at active listening is a lifetime endeavor. However, even minor improvements can make a big difference in your listening effectiveness."

This metaphor from leadership consultants Jack Zenger and Joseph Folkman might also be helpful in understanding what active listening is: "You're not a sponge merely absorbing information. Instead, think of yourself more like a trampoline that gives the speaker's thoughts energy, acceleration, height, and amplification," they write. Here's how to become a so-called trampoline listener.

How to Practice Active Listening?

1. Understand your default listening style.

One of the misconceptions around this soft skill is that there is one way to do it — you're either listening or you're not. But, as authors Rebecca Minehart, Benjamin Symon, and Laura Rock write, there are different styles that you need to be able to shift between, depending on the speaker's needs.

First, it's important to reflect and ask, "How do I usually listen?"

Minehart and her coauthors, in their work in the health care field, observed four distinct listening styles:

- **A task-oriented listener** is focused on efficiency, and shapes a conversation around the transfer of important information.
- **An analytical listener** aims to analyze a problem from a neutral starting point.
- **A relational listener** seeks to build connection and understand and respond to the emotions underlying a message.
- **A critical listener** typically judges both the content of the conversation and the speaker themselves.

You may, out of habit, default to one of these modes in most situations. And that's ok. The key is to develop the awareness to understand which mode you typically use.

Knowing your default style can help you make a conscious, deliberate choice about whether to use that style or choose a different mode that's more appropriate for the specific situation.

2. Make an active, conscious choice about how to best listen.

To determine how to best listen in a particular conversation, ask yourself these questions:

Why do I need to listen right now?

Reflecting on the goals of each particular conversation — both what you want and what the other person needs — can help you determine the best way to listen at that moment. You may realize that a different mode (or combination of modes) would be better. Is a family member in need of emotional support or is a coworker hoping for an honest critique? Using empathy to think about what the other person might need from

your conversation can provide clues as to how you can best listen at that particular moment.

Who is the focus of attention in the conversation?

Sharing your own personal stories can help establish connections and validation, but it's important to avoid steering the conversation away from the speaker so they don't feel unheard or dismissed. All too often, we prevent ourselves from truly being able to listen deeply because of our own insecurities or head-trips — like emotional discomfort or being worried about how confident or prepared we might seem to the other person. With practice, quieting that internal monologue will leave more space to hear what the other person is actually saying.

Why am I talking?

While we all sometimes start rehearsing our response while the other person is talking, it's counterproductive to effective communication. This question reminds us to listen without an agenda so that we can process what the other person is saying. Remind yourself that you can form your thoughts once you've fully heard what they have to say.

At the same time, you don't want to be distracted by your attempts to be present. As Abrahams and Groysberg write, "Eye contact, attentive posture, nodding and other nonverbal cues are important, but it's hard to pay attention to someone's words when you're busy reminding yourself to make regular eye contact. If these sorts of behaviors would require a significant habit change, you can instead, let people know at the beginning of a conversation that you're on the non-reactive side, and ask for their patience and understanding."

At some point in the conversation, you'll likely need to share your perspective but, for now, take in what they have to say. Avoid hijacking the interaction. It's far better to ask questions — it makes the other person feel listened to and increases your comprehension. If you can stay present without judgment or an agenda, you have a better chance of truly hearing what's being said.

Am I still listening?

One of my worst listening habits is deciding that I understand what the person's point is before they finish talking and tuning out. I might even give in to the temptation to multitask. My logic? I've already heard their main ideas, there's no harm in checking my email real quick. Wrong! It's not enough to put down obvious distractions (mobile

phones) at the beginning of the conversation. You need to stay focused.

And, remember it's not just devices or other external things that distract us. It might be your own thoughts or emotions. So if you find your mind wandering, bring your attention back. I find a mantra helpful: "I can deal with that later. Right now, I'm here." Meditation can improve your ability to do this as well.

If you do find your attention pulled away, and you missed something the other person said, don't try to forge ahead as if you know what they're talking about (another bad habit of mine). It's ok to interrupt them and say: "I think I missed what you just said. Could you repeat your last point?"

What am I missing?

Remember, active listening is much more than nodding, saying "Mm- hmm," and parroting back the person's points. Speaking up and asking good questions tells the other person that you've not only heard what they have to say, but you understood it well enough to want additional information.

It can also profoundly change the conversation if you pay attention to verbal and nonverbal cues that might reveal whether the speaker is saying more than what appears at face value. They may be uncertain about being vulnerable or not even realize they are expressing unexamined emotions. Asking questions based on what may have been left unsaid can make the other person feel supported and lead to insight for both of you.

Here's an example.

An employee says, "I'm worried about my presentation for the board meeting."

You might naturally try to reassure and relate by saying, "Oh you're doing great. It took me years before I could present without being nervous."

Unfortunately, while you're attempting to make a connection here, this response dismisses their concern without inviting more details. It switches the focus to you and ignores what might be a much more important underlying issue behind their statement.

To show that you're listening in a deeper way, you could say, "I was nervous when I started presenting, too. What's worrying you?"

Big difference, right?

By asking the above questions anytime you enter a conversation that requires listening (and let's face it, every conversation does!), you'll improve the chances that not only will you hear and glean valuable information but that the other person will feel heard.

Research shows that those who engage in active listening are seen as more

competent, likable, and trustworthy by others.

But it's not just good for you and the other person, research has shown that it also benefits the organization. Active listening behaviors have been positively related to employees' perceptions of support from their managers, which in turn predicts higher levels of job satisfaction and organizational commitment.

With all of these upsides, it's clear that the investment of time and effort in improving your listening skills will pay off.

Vocabulary

序号	英文单词	中文释义	英文例句
1.	attune	v. 使适应；理解；调合	We need to attune to others' thoughts and feelings when practicing active listening.
2.	cognitive	adj. 认知的；认识能力的	The cognitive aspect of active listening means paying attention to all explicit and implicit information.
3.	implicit	adj. 含蓄的；暗示的；内隐的	The speaker didn't say it directly, but we can catch the implicit meaning from his words.
4.	compassionate	adj. 有同情心的；体恤的	We should stay calm and compassionate when having a conversation with someone in trouble.
5.	endeavor	n. & v. 努力；尽力；尝试	Getting good at active listening is a lifetime endeavor for everyone in daily communication.
6.	amplification	n. 放大；增强；阐述	A trampoline listener can give the speaker's thoughts energy and amplification in a talk.
7.	misconception	n. 误解；错误观念	There is a common misconception that active listening is just staying quiet and nodding the head.
8.	distinct	adj. 明显的；清晰的；独特的	Researchers observed four distinct listening styles in the health care field in their study.
9.	deliberate	adj. 深思熟虑的；故意的 v. 仔细考虑	We need to make a deliberate choice about the right listening style for each conversation.
10.	validation	n. 认可；验证；确认	Sharing personal stories can help establish connections and validation between two speakers.
11.	counterproductive	adj. 产生反效果的；适得其反的	Rehearsing your response while listening is counterproductive to effective communication.
12.	agenda	n. 议程；潜在动机；计划	We should listen to others without an agenda to process their words more comprehensively.
13.	mantra	n. 口头禅；箴	A simple mantra can help you bring

		言；咒语	your attention back when your mind wanders while listening.
14.	vulnerable	adj. 易受伤害的；脆弱的；易受影响的	The speaker may feel vulnerable when sharing their true feelings with their colleagues.
15.	glean	v. 收集；搜集（信息、知识等）	You can glean valuable information from a talk if you practice active listening sincerely.
16.	attentive	adj. 专心的；留意的；殷勤的	Being attentive to both words and body language is key to effective active listening.
17.	subtle cues	n. 微妙的线索；细微的暗示	We should learn to recognize subtle cues like tone and facial expressions during communication.
18.	essential	adj. 极其重要的；本质的 n. 要素	Patience is an essential part of developing strong active listening skills.
19.	trampoline	n. 蹦床；弹床	The trampoline is used as a symbol to represent a responsive and supportive listening style.
20.	acceleration	n. 加速；促进；增速	Active listening can lead to the acceleration of mutual understanding between communicators.
21.	default	adj. 默认的；预设的 n. 默认；惯例	Many people fall into a default listening mode that is passive and unfocused.
22.	wander	v. 走神；徘徊；漫步	It's normal for our minds to wander during long conversations, but we need to pull back focus.
23.	hijack	v. 强行打断；霸占（话题/谈话）；劫持	Don't hijack the conversation when someone is sharing their feelings—let them finish first.
24.	rehearse	v. 预先演练；默背（回应）；排练	It's unwise to rehearse your reply while the speaker is talking, as it makes you miss key information.
25.	multitask	v. 同时处理多项任务；一心多用	Trying to multitask during a serious conversation is a sign of poor active listening.
26.	meditation	n. 冥想；沉思（首字母大写表专有概念）	Regular meditation can help you focus better and avoid mind-wandering when practicing active listening.
27.	forge ahead	v. 继续推进；贸然往下说；迎难而上	If you miss what the speaker said, don't forge ahead—ask them to repeat the point politely.
28.	parrot back	短语 v. 机械复述；鹦鹉学舌般重复（无理解）	Parroting back the speaker's words is not real active listening; you need to show true comprehension.
29.	at face value	短语。按表面意思；从字面上看；轻信表面说法	We shouldn't take the speaker's words at face value—we need to read their subtle cues and implicit meaning.

Part I Complete the following paragraph with the most suitable words from the box

attune, misconception, attentive, deliberate, cognitive, essential, wander, compassionate

There is a common 1. _____ that active listening is just staying quiet in a conversation. In fact, it is an 2. _____ communication skill that involves multiple 3. _____ processes, such as reading the speaker's feelings and understanding unspoken meanings. An active listener must be 4. _____ to the speaker's words and 5. _____ not to let their mind 6. _____ or focus on their own response while listening.

Part II Choose the best synonym for the underlined word in each sentence

1. We need to attune ourselves to the subtle changes in the speaker's tone during communication. ()
A. adapt B. oppose C. ignore D. analyze
2. The implicit meaning behind her words made the conversation more meaningful. ()
A. obvious B. hidden C. direct D. funny
3. It is counterproductive to interrupt the speaker while they are expressing their true feelings. ()
A. useful B. harmful C. effective D. necessary
4. When people share their worries, they often feel vulnerable and need more care. ()
A. strong B. confident C. fragile D. calm
5. We can glean valuable information from the speaker's nonverbal behaviors in a talk. ()
A. collect B. lose C. invent D. delete

Part III Decide whether the following statements are true (T) or false (F).

1. Active listening is only about hearing what someone is saying and repeating back their main points. ()
2. Active listening is defined as having three key aspects which are cognitive, emotional and behavioral. ()
3. The four distinct listening styles observed in the health care field include task-oriented and relational listening. ()

4. Regular meditation is mentioned in the article as a way to help avoid mind wandering when listening. ()
5. Rehearsing your response while the other person is talking is believed to be conducive to active listening. ()

Part IV Translate the passage into English using the given words and phrases.

积极倾听是一项关键的沟通技能，包含认知、情感和行为三大维度，远非单纯倾听或机械复述话语。我们要先认清自身的默认倾听风格，再根据沟通场景灵活切换，交流中保持专注共情，不提前演练回应，学会捕捉言语与非言语的细微线索、理解言外之意，这一能力不仅能提升个人的沟通效果，也能为团队和组织发展带来积极作用。(Active listening, cognitive, parrot back, default, compassionate, rehearse, subtle cues)

Part V Further Discussion Questions

1. The article mentions four distinct listening styles (task-oriented, analytical, relational, critical) and points out that people often have a default listening style. What is your **default listening style** in daily communication (e.g., talking with classmates, family or teachers)? Can you give a specific example to explain it, and what situations make you realize you need to shift to another listening style?
2. The author uses the metaphor of a "**trampoline** listener" instead of a "**sponge** listener" to explain active listening. Combining your own experience, what behaviors of a listener will make you feel like you are "talking to a trampoline" (valued and supported)? On the contrary, what behaviors will make you feel your words are just "absorbed by a sponge" (ignored or not valued)?
3. The article states that "rehearsing your response while the other person is talking" is counterproductive to active listening, and many people have this bad habit. Why do you think people tend to rehearse their replies when listening? How do you usually stop yourself from doing this, or what effective methods can you think of to avoid this habit according to the article's tips?